

User Experience

A top MS suit recently stated that the widely hated User Access Control in Vista was not a mistake, but a carefully designed feature. Apparently, Microsoft deliberately wanted to annoy people so that they would not run systems as Administrator, for security reasons. Bravo! Now more people are probably getting infected from malicious sites that offer tips on how to "Disable UAC"



Pot Calls Kettle Black

Steve Shellhorn bought some coins from a man in North Carolina and made a comment on eBay that he felt that the coins were packed poorly. He was promptly sued for \$10,000 by the seller, who alleged that Shellhorn's review "tarnished his reputation". The case fell flat—the seller had no reputation to tarnish—he's a registered sex offender!



Escape

FACE OFF

Bashed Book

Like people, organisations and companies too have their bad days. In such times, a company would find its touch with the normally appreciative press to be shaky and it gets flak for all mistakes—big and small, when the media honeymoon ends and real life begins.

This seems to be happening with Facebook a lot these days. Not long ago, Facebook was this cool new kid in town with most media sites heaping scorn on rivals like MySpace. Starting with the Beacon fiasco, however, Facebook has seen only combative attitudes from the press and millions of users. People were not the least amused when the Beacon started showing purchases made by them on their friend feeds. After the hue and cry, Facebook withdrew

the feature and even though it still gets bad blood over Beacon, it seemed that the worst was behind it.

But Facebook didn't reckon with the litigious tendencies of its American users. Cathryn Harris was embarrassed when her friend's feed showed that



she had purchased a tacky horror movie from an online retailer Blockbuster. We don't know why she wanted to keep her choice of movies hidden from contacts—perhaps she belonged to a club dedicated to shunning tacky horror movies, but she was very clear on her next step. She went ahead and filed a class action suit against Blockbuster, demanding damages for causing mental pain, agony and invasion of privacy. We are following the case with fingers crossed.

In related news, Facebook is messing up its ad placement algorithms. This became known when a user who had kept his sexual preferences as straight had multiple offers from chat Web sites offering to set him up with gay men. Contextual advertising is how social sites are supposed to earn their revenue, and we can't help wondering how fudging up something as

Whatever Happened To...

ZigBee

ZigBee is one of these myriad wireless standards that have a funky name and peddled by a committee called IEEE 802.something.

Touted as a low-power, low-cost and wireless mesh networking standard ZigBee 1.0 specification was ratified in 2004. The basic goal of the standard was to wirelessly network and control heating, lighting and security sensors. The radio frequencies would be short range with a speed of 250 Kbps, enough for such kind of applications. The basic premise was to set up the network once, start it, and replace the battery after four to five years. This seemed ideal for the home segment and analysts and the media were confidently predicting the demise of Bluetooth and the market being awash with ZigBee products very soon.

Fast forward to 2008 and the ZigBee Alliance (the body responsible for standards) has very little to show for their efforts. Personal Area Networks are still ruled by Bluetooth, while newer standards like WiBree are gaining popularity. While there are odd ZigBee products being peddled on the Internet, they're few and far between.

So what happened? ZigBee's proponents say that they were too enthusiastic. However, they also promise that ZigBee's time has finally come and millions of devices using it will be sold very soon. Don't bet money on that happening soon though, and for now, you have to switch the toaster off manually!

DigiPick of the month

The age of the Terabyte!



Last month's winner:

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Kanchipuram

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by Paul McFedries

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E-mail your picture with "DigiPick" in the subject line, mentioning your postal address, **on or before the 20th of this month** to digipick@thinkdigit.com. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.



vital as this is helping their cause. Somebody sure has a lot of explaining to do!

IMMORAL POLICE

Illegal Records

While file sharing and downloading movies isn't a big deal in India, in the west, people go to jail or land up in courts for illegally downloading content. Therefore, it was surprising when a security audit in South Australia police stations yielded movies in computers belonging to hundreds of officers. It has been speculated that all these movies were illegally downloaded using P2P software, either at these computers or transferred from other computers. What tickles the bones of oppressed file sharers and dismayed the anti piracy industry bodies is that authorities have flatly refused to prosecute the officers involved for copyright infringement.

On paper, this "crime" in

Australia carries a stiff penalty of A\$ 60,500 (about Rs 22,72,440) per file and also a jail sentence of 5 years. This means that if the bosses in the South Australian police force heed the anti-piracy body's pleas, then the whole state would face a problem enforcing the law, because hundreds of officers would be broke and behind bars. And come to think of it, when you have problems like drugs and terrorism, file sharing is just a harmless schoolboy prank. People don't get hurt, nobody loses money, artists get free advertisements and the only ones getting pinched are the record labels.

With this decision, it has become harder to make money off selling music and movies in South Australia. People down under complain that they download files because latest movies and TV shows beamed in Australia are about 4 years old! A single DVD also costs an arm and a leg, swelling the ranks of those using Bit Torrent and other P2P applications. Here is a bit of free advice to the suits—lower the prices and

give the Aussies an updated dose of the daily feed of movies and soaps. That would keep them busy. Meanwhile the constabulary can always be offered some complimentary copies so that everybody is happy.

I DO... WHILE GAMING

Bejewelled Liaisons

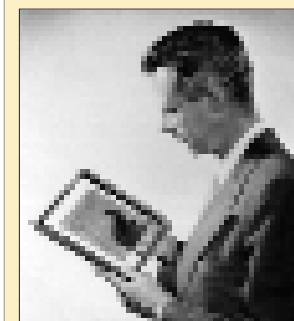
You are a geek! You are great at writing code, serving up spiffy applications and fragging opponents in FPS games. You are the king of all you survey, as long as you only survey your PC. Once you have left those familiar environs, the world and its customs seem too complicated and you make yourself and people around you feel uncomfortable with your lack of social conventions.

That's the reason geeks and nerds don't really have a great life when you take computers out of the scene. Sure, there are many geeks who have girlfriends and singing careers, but on the

People Who Changed Computing

Jay Wright Forrester

Random Access Memory (RAM) was developed by Jay Wright Forrester around 1949. Born in 1918, in Nebraska, Forrester grew up on a cattle ranch. The cattle ranch had no electricity and is believed to have spurred his interest towards



Jay Wright Forrester

electricity. In high school, a young Forrester assembled a 12-volt electrical system from old car parts, which effectively gave the ranch its first electrical power. This was a wind driven system.

Forrester later attended the University of Nebraska and then graduated from the prestigious Massachusetts Institute of Technology. He joined as a research assistant at MIT's high voltage laboratory. After working and pioneering feedback control systems at MIT, he went on to develop the RAM as we know today. We all know the importance of the Random Access Memory, popularly called RAM. Contrary to magnetic media such as hard disk drives, there are no movable parts in the RAM. As a result, this piece of technology significantly boosts up computing speed by reducing the access time required for data read / write cycles. Forrester still serves at the MIT Sloan School of Management.

Win!

My Desktop

No Winner!
Better luck next time!

Participate in this contest and win next month

.net Interview Questions

by Nagaraju B

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



Send us your desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.